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How Useful is Bourdieu's Notion of Cultural Capital for Describing Literary Markets?

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Abstract: Bourdieu's concepts of cultural capital and field, developed in the 1970s and 1980s, still provide systematic reference points for studies interested in literary cultures under market conditions. These concepts have found resonance in studies observing the changing organisation, structure, and social positions involved in the writing, reading, and circulation of literature. While both the conceptual clarity and the historical results Bourdieu achieved (in particular in his study *The Rules of Art*, originally published in 1992) have come under attack, both his key concepts and his multi-method approach function as a theoretical toolbox for present studies. The article discusses three studies (Childress 2017; English 2005; Guillory 1993) which make use of Bourdieu's concept of capital in order to describe contemporary US publishing, the role of literary canons in higher education, and the status of literary awards. I argue that Bourdieu's framework is productive in these cases when it is used in a heuristic way, when the idea of cultural and social capital is considered as processes and practices of valuation, and when it points to the political aspects of economies.

Keywords: Bourdieu, literary market, cultural capital

1 Introduction

The perception of literary markets has changed considerably in the last few years. Rather than treating the sphere of book sales with disdain or suspicion, annual reports on book sales figures are expected and discussed with some anxiety now. Shrinking sales are translated into dwindling numbers of readers, and the observation of the book market is an occasion for voicing pessimism (not always

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justified) about the decline of literary culture.¹ The increasing concentration of publishing and retailing literature through a few multinational corporations causes concerns about the survival chances of independent publishing (McGurl 2016; Sinykin 2019), and a buzzing, diversified, and competitive literary market begins to look like a desirable thing whose loss is to be mourned.

The literary market can be read in the sense of being interpreted and assessed in widely different ways, then. More than ever, it seems difficult to dismiss the literary market from considerations of contemporary literature. In this context, Pierre Bourdieu's study in the cultural sociology of art, *The Rules of Art*, still serves as an obligatory historical and systematic reference point for studies interested in literary cultures under market conditions. The concepts of capital and field in particular have found great resonance (Childress 2017; English 2005; Gelder 2004; Guillory 1993) in studies observing the changing organisation, structure, and social positions involved in the writing, reading, and circulation of literature. Informed by Marxist ideas but also drawing on ethnographic and phenomenological approaches, Bourdieu's cultural sociology proved to be an approach that promised to have it both ways, and to reconcile seemingly disparate perspectives: addressing, in good critical tradition, capitalist economy as a social formation with pervasive impact on society and culture without reducing art and literature to commodities and economic principles. It also promised to reconcile close textual readings with general considerations on political and economic structures, and on a broad range of institutional frameworks of literary culture. Moreover, it encouraged (before and alongside with, for example, actor-network theory) a practice-oriented approach to the self-descriptions of authors, publishers, readers, and other actors in literary culture.²

¹ Sales figures and their significance are often contradictory. The German paper *Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung* deplored a loss of 1 million readers (i.e. book purchases) between 2010 and 2020 (Giersberg 2020, n. pag.). Second-hand purchases are usually not included in these numbers, and it is not clear how many readers a book purchase actually involves. Jim Collins notes a survey-based increase in US reading activity in 2010 (Collins 2010, p. 15), contradicting the widespread fears for a dwindling book market. A similar point is made for the German situation by Carlos Spoerhase and Steffen Martus (2018, p. 8–9). In Britain, a decline in book sales from a peak in 2017 caused some concern in 2019, when also ebook sales decreased (“Consumer ebook sales continued their slow decline, down 2% to £251m. Sales have fallen 20% since 2014, as rising competition for screen time from services such as Netflix, Facebook and YouTube continues to eat away at the popularity of ebooks and ereaders” [Sweeney 2019, n. pag.]). The Covid-19 pandemic seems to turn the situation for the better as more paperbacks and especially “challenging classics” were bought (Flood 2020, n. pag.).

² For a survey of approaches that implicitly and explicitly address literature from a sociological perspective, and pursue similar ends, see English 2010.

Bourdieu's notion of different capitals responds to many of these problem orientations. It signals an intimate connection of cultural with economic practices while still keeping them conceptually separate. His postulate of social and cultural capital alongside and structurally analogous to its economic form forges a more than metaphorical link between economy and aesthetics. Skills, values, prestige, reputation, or social position are considered as forms of capital, "convertible with but irreducible to economic capital" (Beasley-Murray 2000, p. 102). Capital, including economic capital, appears in "guises" (Bourdieu 1986, p. 243), and symbolic and cultural forms are beliefs or an *illusio* concealing economic dynamics.³

Bourdieu develops his model of a relatively autonomous literary field in *The Rules of Art* with regard to mid- and late-nineteenth century France, and it is limited to a period extending no farther than the middle of the twentieth century. In this period, the literary field sustains itself by an internal division into two mutually excluding but at the same time interdependent subfields: a sphere of allegedly pure, disinterested literary production (or restricted production) defines itself against a profit-oriented mass literary market. While it obeys economic imperatives, it cultivates the logic of "loser wins" – lack of profitability signals artistic worth and prestige, and it pivots on a self-description as "anti-economic" (Bourdieu 1995, p. 82). A key aim of Bourdieu's study is to put this anti-economic rhetoric to the test, and to reconstruct a period when the suspicious and disdainful reading of the literary market became a vital part of the definition of the literary in France (and in other countries of the global north).

My survey will discuss three studies making use of Bourdieu's concept of capital in order to show how this notion still manages to address vital issues of literary culture under conditions of a capitalist market, but I will also point out where it fails productively. I am not assessing in how far Clayton Childress (2017), John Guillory (1993), and James F. English (2005) might have misread or misapplied Bourdieu (or where Bourdieu departed from Marx when he appropriated his concept of capital, for that matter). My survey attempts to present these studies as facets of an ongoing discussion and adoption of Bourdieusian ideas that shares conceptual tools and reaches interesting insights with them while it also points to their limits and suggests directions which further studies could take.

³ In this, Bourdieu's model accommodates a Marxist critique of ideology.

2 Enthusiasm

Clayton Childress's study *Under The Cover: The Creation, Production and Reception of a Novel* (2017) picks up methodologically where Bourdieu began: in ethnography.⁴ It is a fieldwork-based investigation into the conception, writing, publishing, publicizing, and reading of a single novel, Cornelia Nixon's *Jarrettsville* (2009), with a focus on the USA. Childress never loses sight of numbers representing, for example, the relative sizes of publishing houses, market shares, and sales figures, or the social and ethnic composition of staff in the publishing business. His key aim, though, is to attend to the concrete interactions and practices involved in the making of a novel. This involves a reconstruction of the writing process from the author's notes and interviews, and following, as a field researcher, large parts of the process that took her – and/or her manuscript that eventually became a book – through meetings with literary agents, copyeditors, book cover designers, book fair presentations, public readings, reading groups, and critical reviews. Methodologically, Childress is interested in differentiating and complementing Bourdieu's model in light of the contemporary literary field. In contrast to earlier studies on popular and middlebrow fiction (e.g. Gelder 2004), his focus is no longer on the dichotomy of Bourdieu's subfields of restricted and mass production. Childress studies the transitions between different domains within the field: the demarcations and transition points between creation, distribution, and reception.⁵ The vocabularies and narratives used by representatives of the different roles, professions, institutions, and organisations in these subfields create what Bourdieu calls an "economy of practices" (Bourdieu 1986, p. 242) couched in "rules of the game" (Bourdieu 1995, p. 226). They make up the discursive scaffolding that allows authors, publishers, readers, and others to present themselves to other actants in the field, and to accomplish their goals. Somewhat contrary to the expectation of

⁴ His first major work, *Outline of a Theory of Practice* (1977, originally published in 1972), is based on ethnographic fieldwork among the Kabyles in North Africa conducted in the 1950s and 1960s.

⁵ Bourdieu's model of a dichotomic literary field has been criticised for paying too little attention to the middlebrow section (Fowler 1997, p. 148) and to the popular segment. Ken Gelder's *Popular Fiction: The Logics and Practices of a Literary Field* (2004) redresses the latter imbalance. Considering the division into mass and high literature as still intact (Gelder 2004, p. 159), he complements rather than expands Bourdieu's model. A rethinking of basic assumptions can be found in studies on literary culture and literary market development since the 1990s; Jim Collins (2010) argues, for example, that the growing dominance of conglomerate book publishing and retailing gives rise to a reconfiguration of bourgeois reading culture within a nonhierarchical segmentation of the literary field.

relatively autonomous subfields and institutions within the literary field, though, the vocabulary⁶ used within and between the organisations of US publishing in Childress's sample is rather uniform. Expressing enthusiasm turns out to be the key mode for conveying a text from author to agent to publisher to marketing staff, reviewers, booksellers, and finally, readers. Loving the book, being excited or enthusiastic about it, are omnipresent pronouncements. The display of positive emotion is vital, for example for

an editor in a publishing house, in which the bestowment or withholding of positive feelings is the primary tool through which she adjudicates on which books her time will be spent, the conveyance of emotions *is less a form of labor than a form of capital*: granting or withholding enthusiasm for a project is ultimately a tool to get her way. An editor cannot be indiscriminate in the deployment of her enthusiasm – *like all forms of capital, its stock can be depleted with use* – but, more than anything else, it is the promissory note of enthusiasm from an editor that gets the gears of a publishing house moving towards her interests. (Childress 2017, p. 99; emphasis added)

Childress presents the display of emotion as a limited resource that has to be dispensed in limited amounts in order to achieve certain effects. This terminology is in accordance with Bourdieu's model, which rests on four basic types of capital – cultural, social, symbolic, and economic – and introduces further, field-specific kinds.⁷ Erik Neveu sums up Bourdieu's notion of cultural and social capital as “a collection of goods and skills, of knowledge and acknowledgements, belonging to an individual or a group that he or she can mobilize to develop influence, gain power or bargain other elements of this collection”

⁶ Childress observes that “[s]torytelling about sales is, for editors, another way to convey their *enthusiasm* for a project” (Childress 2017, 98; original emphasis), but that the narratives or pitches are adjusted depending on occasion – pitching a review involves less information about the book's plot and emotional appeal and depends more on the editors' evaluation of the book and the author (Childress 2017, p. 170).

⁷ Bourdieu uses the terms of political, educational or informational capital (Neveu 2018, p. 348), or “emotional investment” (Bourdieu 1986, p. 257), and scholars have happily added to the list. Neveu convincingly argues that only three types of capital or more precisely, three symbolic manifestations or “guises” (Bourdieu 1986, p. 243) in which capital appears, need to be distinguished, namely economic, cultural, and social capital. Other field-specific kinds are composed of them. The status of economic and symbolic capital is not entirely clear in Bourdieu's writings. Symbolic capital is not so much a fourth type but a general characteristic of all capitals since, as Bourdieu states in accordance with Marx's notion of capital as a social relation, they come in ‘guises’ and manifest themselves as economic, social, or cultural. Bourdieu's terminology is not always consistent, though: he also claims that economic capital is an unambiguous and transparent, and therefore an undisguised form of transaction (Bourdieu 1986, p. 252) underpinning the other forms. Symbolic capital would then only comprise cultural and social capital. The latter use of the term can be found frequently in secondary literature.

(Neveu 2018, p. 347).⁸ Cultural capital, for example, can be a set of objects like paintings, musical instruments, or machines, but it is also embodied as an acquired habitus or a set of skills (Bourdieu 1986, p. 3); social capital consists of “a durable network of more or less institutionalized relationships of mutual acquaintance and recognition” (Bourdieu 1986, p. 248) and depends on group membership.

Childress reads the display of intense positive emotion as a strategy used, for example by editors, to justify their selections of publishable texts without having to give further reasons. ‘Enthusiasm’ is basically a “shorthand” (Childress 2017, p. 76) expressing an estimate about artistic ability as well as market feasibility; it is a “free-floating signifier” (Childress 2017, 100) that can convey an amazing variety of messages: “perceptions of artistic ability, personal tastes, market feasibility and publisher fit” (Childress 2017, p. 99). This is in accordance with Bourdieu’s claim that both social and cultural capital are “objectively economic [...] [but] cannot be socially recognized as economic” (Bourdieu 1986, p. 243). The political dimension of enthusiasm as a deliberately fuzzy shorthand term for justifying decisions on publishability is elaborated by Childress when he observes (and supports with statistical evidence) that the emphasis on personal experience, taste, and affinity with books means that only a specific, namely a white middle-class experience is considered as valid, and that authors of colour as well as publishing staff of colour are glaringly underrepresented in US publishing.⁹

But in what sense is enthusiasm capital? Showing excitement, Childress notices, is also an important means to generate corresponding emotional intensity in other decision-makers. It is therefore not only representative of experiences and acquired skills but also productive: the richness of significations carried by expressions of enthusiasm includes messages about professional status, experience, position, and reputation. An “editor cannot be indiscriminate in the deployment of her enthusiasm” (Childress 2017, p. 99). Childress (like Moore 2014) uses the term ‘capital’ in the sense of wealth, in the sense of a stock that can be depleted. Capacities like being able to judge artistic quality, taste and business sense are not depleted in interactions, though, and the skilled

⁸ Cultural and social capitals are also characterised by relational value and yield (they do not have essential value and their usefulness may fluctuate), convertibility (into economic advantage), and embodiment (Neveu 2018, p. 347).

⁹ “With regard to racial diversity in the occupation, in the 2014 *Publishers Weekly*’s Salary Survey, 88 percent of the responding editors identified as white, with 3.7% identifying as Asian, 2.8% as Hispanic (any race), 2.8% as mixed race and 1.4% as Black. While the lack of racial diversity among editors can be attributed to a variety of causes, the result is a highly stratified population of editors who are at least partially selecting manuscripts based on works that match their own tastes, sensibilities and experiences” (Childress 2017, p. 95).

production and use of emotion in a meeting is, contrary to Childress's observation, indeed closer to labour than to distributing an amassed stock of valuables. Marx considers capital as a socially constituted relation and, more importantly, as a surplus-generating *process* realised only in circulation.¹⁰ These distinguishing features of capital can perhaps describe the situations Childress observes more accurately. An emphasis on an accumulation process rather than static quantity captures the flow and the production of "social energy" (Bourdieu 1986, p. 253) in situations in which professional expertise, acquired experience and a person's social and professional reputation (or, cultural and social capital and position in the field) are *performed* and *mobilised*.¹¹

3 Cultural Capital

John Guillory's adoption of the term 'cultural capital' inscribes itself into the political rather than economic problem orientation for which Bourdieu coined the term in the first place. The notion of cultural capital appears as early as 1969, in Bourdieu's *The Love of Art*, and in *Reproduction in Education, Society, and Culture*, co-authored with Jean-Claude Passeron in 1970 (Neveu 2018, p. 349). The terms of cultural, social, and economic capital gradually replace Bourdieu and Passeron's earlier "notions such as *privilège culturel* (cultural privilege)" (Neveu 2018, p. 350; original emphasis). First introduced to explain how the educational system shores up rather than decreases social inequality, cultural capital turns into a keyword in

10 Amassing a certain amount of money, commodities, or other material or immaterial goods that have been endowed with value in an act of exchange is not capital but wealth. As Michael Heinrich's explanation makes clear, Marx's term 'capital' refers to the surplus generated in a series of exchanges geared towards increasing the initial amount, not towards conserving it: "A single act of exchange also does not make capital out of a particular sum of value. Only the linking of various exchange processes with the purpose of increasing the initial sum of value yields the typical *movement of capital*: capital is not merely value, but rather *self-valorizing value*" (Heinrich 2004, p. 86 and 87; original emphasis). Value is generated whenever work is strategically under-valued and labour time subjected to an abstract standard (Beasley-Murray 2000, p. 10), so that additional labour time can be skimmed off as a surplus.

11 These structural parallels do not contribute to the open question to what extent aesthetic and economic value are identical, convertible, or comparable, and whether art can be described as a commodity. Beech (2015) argues that none of the extant economic theories manages to fully explain art, including attempts such as Beasley-Murray's (2000) who argues that Bourdieu's concept of artistic skills is exploitable as labour time (and thus part of the surplus production of capitalism) (Beech 2015, p. 239 and 254). My thanks to Marlon Lieber and Dennis Büscher-Ulbrich, whose steady supply of relevant texts for this discussion was a great help while taking the first tentative steps into a new research field.

Distinction (1979), another study on how cultural tastes, preferences, and practices both express and reproduce class differences. Guillory's *Cultural Capital: The Problem of Literary Canon Formation* focuses on the institution of higher education and the role of canons in the preservation of social hierarchies. For Guillory, capital is understood as wealth, or a stock of valuable possessions as well:

If the current educational institution does indeed (like every other social institution) reproduce social inequities, it achieves this effect by *the unequal distribution of cultural capital*, or by presenting cultural works in the classroom as the organic expression of the dominant classes' entitlement to those works. [...] The claim of the present argument is that an analysis of this crisis in terms of the *distribution of cultural capital* will produce a more strategic theory of curricular reform than will a pluralist critique. (Guillory 1993, p. 54; emphasis added)

Guillory merely implies that the exclusivity attributed to canonised literature in higher education is a key obstacle to its wider circulation – picking up on Bourdieu's insistence on the “scarcity” of cultural and social capital (Bourdieu 1986, p. 248). Jon Beasley-Murray suggests that, rather than creating an artificial shortage and limiting the *distribution* of cultural capital, the education system might be conceived of as an institution that *valorizes* cultural capital in a too selective way (Beasley-Murray 2000, p. 113). This view remains implicit in Guillory's argument, for example when he draws attention to the historicity of canonical decisions (Guillory 1993, p. 59 and p. 60) or to acts of attribution of literary or aesthetic value in different reading communities (Guillory 1993, p. 279). Translating such considerations into teaching and curriculum-design practice, though, will look very different depending on which view one chooses – is it a matter of multiplying access options to established culture, or is it (also) necessary to change and diversify the criteria that qualify something as culture in the first place?

The issue of value attribution and the role of institutions in this process is also an open question in Bourdieu's model of the literary field, in particular as regards its allegedly openly commercial section. Both Guillory and Bridget Fowler perceive the Bourdieusian model as deficient in not offering a discussion of “the clashes over cultural value in which some popular genres of writing are systematically excluded from the literary field, or their productions neglected” (Fowler 1997, p. 151; see Guillory 1993, p. 271). Fowler takes the critical assessment of Bourdieu's relative neglect of the field of mass literary production further when she elaborates the systematic and conceptual reasons for Bourdieu's relative neglect of the popular. In *The Rules of Art*, Bourdieu shows how aesthetic discourses legitimise and organise a so-called anti-economic economy of highbrow literature: the stylisation of disinterestedness, the disdain for commercial success, and the ideal of producing for peers rather than an audience are all described as the *illusio* or belief that disguises but by no means eliminates the economic calculations and the power-oriented

struggles for position underpinning all activities in the highbrow segment of the literary field. It is of key importance that the values invoked in aesthetic discourse are defined in contradistinction to economic value or use value.

As Fowler observes, “Bourdieu has hardly started the work of mapping the contemporary field of popular culture in these terms, but rather assumes a priori that all popular culture will be devoid of formal interest and written with withered ideological matrices” (Fowler 1997, p. 162). Bourdieu's systematic framework forecloses any attempt to conduct an equally fine-grained investigation into the popular segment of the literary field: being reduced to the economic from the outset, the field of mass literature is presented largely in terms of sales figures and publisher reports, but neither writers nor readers and their preferences, criteria, or valuation practices are considered. Bourdieu devotes much less space to their study and describes the field of mass production exclusively in terms of economic capital and the vocabulary of short-term profits, gains, investments, revenue, and numerical quantities of sales. The impression created by this account is that the popular literary market and the field that clusters around it do not feature any kinds of valuation – cultural and social capitals – apart from economic valorization. The field of the popular therefore seems void of discourses, practices, habitus, skills, dispositions, social networks, and institutions that correspond to the elaborately analysed cathedrals of higher-class self-reproduction through cultural and social capital. Janice Radway's *Reading the Romance* has certainly become another important reference point in studies of literary culture because it does not attempt to explain popular literature in terms of the standards of the high literary subfield (as Fowler sometimes does) but shows genuine interest in the categories by readers of romance fiction themselves.

4 Exchange

Apart from capital, exchange is a key term in Bourdieu's project of a “general science of the economy of practices, which would treat mercantile exchange as a particular case of exchange in all its forms” (Bourdieu 1986, p. 242). It is also prominent in James English's *The Economy of Prestige* (2005), a study on the function of literary awards in negotiating relative reputation inside and outside the literary field. For English, Bourdieu's model is appealing because it steers clear of reducing all cultural phenomena to economic ones but nevertheless acknowledges how economic dynamics bear on culture (English 2005, p. 4). Literary prizes are highly contested rather than readily accepted markers of literary quality (English 2005, p. 187 and p. 188), but, like the multiple significations of enthusiasm in contemporary publishing, they function as points of

transition between the aesthetic and the economic (English 2005, p. 8). When Nobel or Booker prize-winning books are more marketable, their success rests on the acceptance in the economic sphere of credentials and value attributions from outside the market; for the same reason, the (allegedly economic) ranking and evaluation procedures involved in assigning prizes come under critical scrutiny. Looking at literary prizes means to explore the “economic dimensions of culture, [...] the rules or logics of exchange in the market for what has come to be called ‘cultural capital’” (English 2005, p. 3).

Literary prizes, though, are financial endowments that also strain against the concept and the logic of exchange at the heart of notions of a market and an ‘economy of practices.’ Bourdieu’s sociology is meant to include non-capitalist forms of exchange (for example in the supposedly pre-capitalist Kabyle communities he studied as an ethnographer in the 1960s) and, within the concept of cultural capital, the intergenerational transmission of mental and physical attitudes or *habitus*. Here, a concept of exchange whose profit- and power-oriented aspects are detectable only indirectly, and sometimes only as long-term effects, comes into play. Despite of that, even seemingly disinterested practices like education or gift giving, Bourdieu claims, are means of a strategic struggle for power and future gain. For English, literary awards seem to be “escaping or exceeding the terms of exchange” (English 2005, p. 6) or, more precisely, mercantile exchange because “one cannot generally bargain or haggle for one. One cannot demand a bigger prize for one’s artistic efforts as one might demand a higher price for them” (English 2005, p. 5). While they express or create reputation and prestige for givers and receivers and in this respect resemble gifts, this renown and status is far from being unquestioned: “What sort of event or system of exchange is this, which seems to secure cultural esteem by maximizing the flow of disesteeming discourse through and around it?” (English 2005, p. 188)

While the regular debates about whether a particular writer actually deserved a particular award may still be remnants of the ‘loser wins’ logic of the high literary field, the effects of the global reach of literary awards like the Nobel Prize in Literature and to a lesser extent the Booker Prize, discussed in English’s concluding chapter, complicate the picture. When Akinwande Oluwale Babatunde Soyinka received the Nobel prize in 1986 as the first African writer, the Nobel committee’s presentation of Soyinka as a representative of universal values came under critical scrutiny (for failing to reflect the local roots of European and US criteria for literary value), and Soyinka himself was criticized for endorsing European forms and issues at the expense of his native Nigerian (or Yoruba) traditions. To what extent the world literature that, as English claims, was to a large extent created by transnational literary awards since the late 1980s actually leaves intact or even reinforces these criteria of literariness, though, is not clear. English suggests that world literature

always addresses the local as it is affected by undeniable global economic and political structures, and vice versa. The very contested and precarious status of literary prizes, then, may serve to maintain an awareness for the problems involved in a transnationalization of cultural economies.¹²

5 Cultural Capital?

One of the results of *The Economy of Prestige* is insight into the deep entanglement of aesthetic with political and economic issues, and the difficulty of untangling them in order to define one of them as a driving force. This begs the well-known questions whether art and literature are a special case of capitalist economy or a special case of the political (Bennett 2010, p. 115).¹³ A third and equally well-worn question, which I consider nevertheless more productive, is asking how well concepts serve as tools for *bricolage*. A term like exchange, modelled on mercantile exchange, emerges as indispensable and at the same time lacking in explanatory scope when English uses it to explain prestige, bound up with highly contested and perhaps even dubious status; the concept nevertheless draws attention to an undue cultural dominance of the global north on a global scale. A similar conclusion can be drawn from Childress's study, where the notion of capital as wealth proved terminologically inaccurate but nevertheless pointed to moments when mobilizing 'enthusiasm' concealed the restricted access of minority writers and writers of colour to the US publishing system. And finally, the idea that social hierarchy and political dominance as an outcome of unequally distributed cultural capital that can be found in English, Guillory, and Bourdieu might be more productively phrased as the question how institutions – the higher education sector as well as institutions of literary valuation catering indirectly to literary markets – produce and attribute cultural value.

¹² "The Nobel's foray into Africa is part of the strengthening of a global economy of literary prestige that often draws upon and makes profitable use of national literary hierarchies and systems of value, but without simply affirming or reproducing them and at times by discounting them quite radically" (English 2005, p. 305, cf. p. 298).

¹³ Acknowledging this difficulty, Jonathan Clover and Christopher Nealon (arguing in a Marxist context) point to the futility of separating the domains, fields, or spheres of art, economy, and politics at all because they suspect it will result in an idealization of art and distract from the pervasiveness of the capitalist value form (Clover and Nealon 2017, p. 18). Fredric Jameson's (2008, p. 579–80) scathing critique of Bourdieu's concepts of capitals and fields – which indeed encourage thinking in separate domains, and may prevent a deeper analysis of economic conditions – is launched with a similar intent, but ultimately adds little to Adorno's position that there is no escape from and no outside vantage point to capitalism.

Despite the conceptual shortcomings, the empirical lacunae, the focus on static positions and relations rather than on practices in time and the datedness of Bourdieu's model of a dichotomic literary field, one of the potentials of his term cultural capital may still be its capacity to point to the inseparability of political issues (that is, dominance, hierarchy, social exclusion) from economic ones. Here, Bourdieu's wider sense of a decidedly *political economy of practices* indeed rules out the existence of a disinterested or indifferent (and at the same time an essentially subversive) position for art and literature. If this perspective is not mistaken for a pronouncement of an inherent essence of art and literature but as an assessment of the approximate but always historically specific role that literature and art play in social practices, which are in turn informed by contesting discourses, it can work productively as a heuristic approach.

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